Before A Discussion Round

Here are some general guidelines for being as prepared and ready to compete you will want to do before every round of discussion.

Equipment

These are essential pieces of equipment that should be brought with you to each round:

1. An internet-capable device to access research, ex: iPad, laptop, Chromebook. Be sure the device is fully charged before the tournament! You may want to bring a charger with you in case your battery runs low.
2. A name tent which will sit on the table in front of your device so everyone can see your name when addressing you in round. Fold a normal piece of printer paper 3 times to form a triangle and write your name in large script so everyone can see your name. Some students will add their preferred pronouns, others will include their speaker code for that tournament.
3. Something to write notes with. A pencil or pen, and a notebook for example.
4. A refillable water bottle. A speech tournament is a long day with lots of talking. You will need to stay hydrated throughout the day.
5. A phone with a wireless hotspot. While this isn't a requirement, per se, it can come in handy in situations where the school WiFi is unstable or coverage is spotty. Also bring your phone charger!

These are some other items which you may want to consider bringing with you to the tournament (not to the round):

1. Snacks. You would not actually bring food to your rounds, but in general it is good to have snacks with you to keep you energized and nourished throughout the day., and possibly bring your own lunch. There will be time to eat lunch (usually between the second and third rounds). Concessions can sometimes have a long line,
2. Your lunch. There is usually enough time between your second and third rounds to eat lunch. Schools will always offer concessions. You may want to skip concessions if you have specific dietary needs, don't want to wait in a line, or want to save money.
3. Something warm to wear. The bus can be incredibly cold. Schools can be incredibly cold. You may want to bring articles of clothing that can be worn over your speech attire (blanket, sweats, warm shoes) in between rounds to warm up.

Task Publishing

You will want to have a solid understanding of how a tournament intends to publish their tasks. Your coaches usually can help you determine where and how tasks are being published. There are generally two methods:

Electronically

Many tournaments in the metro area have adopted online publications of their tasks, which means usually there is a shared Google doc you will want to open and monitor throughout the day. Some of these tournaments that publish electronically may release tasks in advance. The Odyssey (Orono/Westonka shared tournament) usually releases their prelim tasks the week prior. We have seen some tournaments release all of their tasks at the beginning of the tournament in the morning. The important thing to do is to open that shared Google doc as soon as you are aware of it (could be that morning, could be in the days prior to the tournament).

If a tournament releases a task before the round, use your time before that round starts to analyze the task and prepare your research.

On Paper

There are fewer and fewer tournaments which release tasks “the old fashioned way”. Which is to say, on paper. These tournaments will hand the judge an envelope with enough copies of the task printed on paper. When the judge is ready to begin your round, they will distribute those papers face down to each of the discussants. As soon as your group turns their papers over to start reading, that is when the judge will start the round.

Arrive At Your Round Early

Give yourself enough time to locate where you will be competing and get set up. Many tournaments will have preliminary rounds of Discussion at tables spread throughout a gymnasium. Some smaller tournaments may have rounds compete inside classrooms. Final rounds often will be in a classroom.

Most of the tournaments during the regular season will not have assigned seating order. Sections and State will require that students sit in the order from the judge's left-to-right based on the speaking order published on the round schematic.

If you are able to, try to determine where the judge is likely to sit. If you can pick where you sit, try to sit as close to the judge as possible. This will help the judge better hear and see you throughout the round.

Set up your equipment on the table, and get comfortable. Determine whether there are any WiFi issues in your location (there often are). You may need to jump on a wireless hotspot if you can't access the internet.

Icebreakers

The core philosophy of Discussion strongly emphasizes cooperation and achieving consensus. The category is not intended to be adversarial.

Fundamental to Building Relationships

Since you are randomly paired with competitors from different schools for each round, your primary goal is to build relationships in order to work together more effectively. Once you are set up at your table, you will want to break the ice and start to get to know the other students in your round. Using icebreakers before the 60-minute round begins serves to quickly establish the necessary spirit of collaboration required for the event, through:

- Relationship Building: The goal of forming early relationships supports the philosophy of Discussion that it will be a positive exchange of ideas, and for students to develop collaborative skills. Starting with a non-competitive social interaction promotes this cooperative dynamic before the structured round activities begin.
- The Topic Context: This year's topic, "The Future of Belonging: Finding Community In A Fragmented World", directly addresses issues of fragmentation. Using a pre-round icebreaker to bridge the gap between students from different schools reinforces the goal of building community and reducing fragmentation, setting a positive precedent for the discussion to follow.

Strategic Use of Icebreakers to Identify Allies and Opponents

Your secondary goal—identifying potential allies or those who might be hard to work with—is a sophisticated competitive tactic that may give you important insights into the discussion styles of your competitors.

Some students are overly aggressive, and try to control the early mechanics of the round, such as prematurely setting agendas. Such students often score well in preliminary rounds. These "project manager" discussants seek early control and may try to impose their will on the group.

By observing students during the low-stakes, pre-round icebreaker, you may gain insight into who is likely to:

1. Be an "Aggressive Project Manager": If a student takes immediate, commanding control of the icebreaker, dominates the conversation, or uses the time to assert expertise, they may be an overly aggressive discussant who tries to control the mechanics later in the round (e.g., by insisting on reading the task aloud or immediately proposing an agenda before Clarifications).
2. Be a "Conciliatory Unifier": Students who demonstrate strong listening skills, are amiable, or actively attempt to include others in the casual conversation may be identified as potential collaborators. These are the students who tend to perform better in

final rounds and MSHSL tournaments (Sections, State) because they excel at being good listeners, and unifiers who can synthesize and summarize information.

In short, the pre-round observation helps you decide whether you will need to take charge in early rounds against aggressive competitors, or switch tactics to be more conciliatory and more of a supporter if you find you are paired with collaborative members.

Examples

Some classic examples of icebreakers that would work in a Discussion setting are:

- Two Truths And A Lie. Each person comes up with 2 truths and one lie about themselves. Then everyone else has to guess which was the lie.
- Have You Ever? Come up with leading questions, such as “Have you ever flown in an airplane?” and ask the group. Have several such questions ready to throw out to the group.
- Would you rather? Come up with pairings of items, such as “Would you rather have cake or pie?” and ask the group. Have several such pairings ready to throw out to the group.
- Find 10 Things In Common. This one might be a little more challenging to pull off, but the idea is to identify things that every student has in common. How many of you woke up before 5am? How many of you like the color red?

If the idea of having icebreakers like these ready isn’t your speed, the concept of an icebreaker is simply to get to know everyone. This is the art of small talk, where you want to start conversations with everyone and learn more about each other. Whether you use structured icebreakers, or you simply start off with, “did you see the game last night?” or “how about the weather today?”. These are ways to get the conversation rolling and begin building these essential relationships before your round starts.

Precautions

It is also important that your icebreaker doesn’t negatively influence other participants in the round. This includes your judge, who may also arrive a little before the round (and the judge also will need a little bit of time to get set up). Make sure you aren’t straying into conversations that could be offsetting to others. Stick to topics that are safe and relatively free of controversy. Also, try not to identify your school, where you live, what grade or how old you are to the other participants. This can introduce unconscious bias and dissuade other students from wanting to collaborate with you; a judge could be a recent alum from a “rival” high school and could be influenced knowing where you go to school. Try to avoid topics of politics or religion, as these can also be sources of friction between people.